

BROKEN BLUEPRINTS

The absence of major teams at the 2026 FIFA World Cup is a cruel reminder that history counts for little when the system is **cracked from within.**

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As you read this, teams are taking shape, players are pushing to make it to their national sides, and coaches are scratching their heads to get strategies in place before the greatest show on earth rolls into town.

Amid the noise, there is silence in two prominent parts of the world — countries that, not so long ago, were part of this carnival: Italy and Nigeria.

Italy, the more decorated of the two, missed out on its third consecutive World Cup appearance — a phenomenon termed an ‘apocalypse’ by local media — as the four-time World Cup winner lost 1-4 on penalties to Bosnia and Herzegovina in its final qualifier.

The Germans offer a relevant precedent here. When Germany — then a three-time

Shadow of the past: Italian football DNA, shaped by former coaches like Giovanni Trapattoni and Arrigo Sacchi, rested on a simple creed: defence wins titles. That structure now lies in ruin.

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